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Bobby Johnson Jr.

Bobby Johnson Jr. was born in Pensacola, Florida on July 11, 1915. He earned the nickname "Little Satch" after taking up the trumpet at age ten, and played in the Pensacola High School Band where his bandmates included Benny Carter and Panama Francis. Bobby moved to New York City in 1923 to join the Claude Hopkins Band, later becoming a member of the Erskine Hawkins Orchestra and recording the trumpet solo on their hit "Tippin' In." He performed with King Oliver, Duke Ellington, Benny Goodman and numerous other jazz stars. Bobby played nightly for seven years at the Savannah Club in Greenwich Village and helped break into the segregated music scene that existed in downtown New York.

Bobby was interviewed in Ellenville, New York on June 23, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in the Catskills. And I am extremely pleased to have trumpeter and veteran musician Bobby Johnson Jr. with me. Thank you so much for coming.

BJ: Thank you.

MR: You have just been telling me some fascinating things, and we'll have to tell them again. But you grew up in Pensacola, Florida?

BJ: That's right.

MR: It seems to me I've heard about some other fine musicians who came out of that high school.

BJ: Oh sure. About I would say, roughly about ten. For a small town like that, if I may I'll name some. The concert pianist Don Shirley; Junior Cook, a famous jazz saxophonist; and Gigi Gryce, one of the founders of bebop; well myself. Then we've had a fine bunch of musicians, white musicians, one was Tony Bruno, a famous trumpet player, he came out of Pensacola; and then we had Ray Brown was born there, Ray Brown, the famous bass player. So I would say about ten. And one of the, I'll never be able to reason why because people, during the time I was a kid, people didn't have a place to go. The only place to go was like Sunday night dances. And Pensacola was one of the few towns on the Gulf Coast that had dances, big bands, like on Sunday night. And it somehow got around that they had two — east side, like any other small town, they had an east side and a west side. And one side of the town was more sedate than the other, and they had two or three different bands. But the bands from New Orleans like Papa Celestin, Don Alberts, a great band from Houston, Texas, from New Orleans, and most all of the bands from around New Orleans, they paid a visit on Sunday night. Now I have to tell you that admission was twenty cents.

MR: Twenty cents.

BJ: And things were so rough during those days, people saved up twenty cents to go hear a band. Then we had the college bands. The college bands, Alabama State Collegians which became the Erskine Hawkins Orchestra, and which became a place where I spent most of my life, the best years of my life, recording years. Then we had some bands from Florida A&M College. In other words, during those days the college bands was the thing, because there was only, a kid didn't have to have a scholarship, all he could do is play, play great and have a big name you know all over the south and the next thing, the dean and everyone was likely trying to get this guy, because you remember that Erskine Hawkins, from Alabama State Teachers College, then as we know, we know where the Adderley brothers came from, Florida A&M. Then we had, further up north, we had the Duke Blue Devils, now you know who they were, that was Les Brown. Then we had Kay Kyser from the University of North Carolina. In other words having bands was the big thing in colleges during those days. I don't know now, I read *Down Beat* and different magazines and things like that and I see where they're having college bands contests and all of that.

MR: They're more for concerts, not dancing though.

BJ: What's that now?

MR: They're more for concerts and not dances.

BJ: Right.

MR: Now what made you want to play the trumpet as a young boy?

BJ: It's a funny story. I always wanted to sing. And I used to go around singing and humming and going on you know [humms], so people called me "Little Satch." And I didn't know, and you may not believe this, but they gave us some used instruments from the other high school across town and I picked out the cornet and you wouldn't believe that I started to play and the first note that I ever played, and the first thing I ever played was "When You're Smiling" and when I found out that I was playing "When Your Smiling" in seven sharps, so that means push all the valves down, you understand what I mean?

MR: Right.

BJ: So I learned how to play that, then I learned how to play other songs, and then everyone called me "Little Satch" and I was the big thing around Pensacola. But my mother insisted that I go to this other fella I mentioned, who was named Tony Bruno. And he had been to New York. And one night he heard me play, and he said, "Why don't you come by my house one day" and — you won't believe this — he said, "Why don't you come by my house one day and come to the front door" he said to me. During those days he said to me, "Come to the front door," and my mother — "and bring your horn." He ushered me into the living room, during those days, and taught me to play the trumpet.

MR: And he was white.

BJ: Yes. So that's one of the ways. Now there are several other stories. I knew during those days that Louis Armstrong was very popular with the ladies you know. It's easy to keep up with Satch's age, because he was born in 1900. And frankly I wasn't too far behind him, I was born in 1915, and my father was what we would call a ragtime piano player. As a matter of fact my father was the one who did the piano roll on "There'll Be Some Changes Made." And his name was Bobby Johnson. He had a lot to do with me, gave me my first horn, bought me my first good horn, a King trumpet, and he heard me play after I had joined Erskine Hawkins' band, which I imagine you've heard, the million record seller we had was called "Tippin' In." And it's still great. I got twenty-one dollars for it.

MR: Twenty-one dollars?

BJ: Twenty-one dollars from RCA Victor. Some friends of mine, lawyers and people have been trying to say that I should sue them. For what? I had, you know what I mean?

MR: You had the pleasure of the music, anyway.

BJ: Yeah. I got a chance to do something that will be heard the rest of my life.

MR: Now I understand your mother owned a speakeasy, or a restaurant?

BJ: My mother?

MR: Yes.

BJ: Oh yeah. Well that's true. That's the reason why I knew so many musicians. During those days, this was during the days of prohibition. And each town, like the high sheriff or whoever, you could get into his pocket, he would allow one speakeasy on a certain side of town. And we had just one. I lived on the east side of Pensacola. But sometimes I don't particularly care too much about it, but Pensacola I could say that it wasn't a Jim Crow town, it was like, I lived, to be frank with you, I came up in an exclusive white neighborhood. But we ran a speakeasy that had all kinds of clientele. And we got away with it. But when the Volstead Act came along, that was prohibition you know, President Roosevelt, we tried to get a liquor license and we couldn't get it, and we found ourselves in New York. Now the way this happened, maybe you've heard of a famous clarinet player named Edmond Hall.

MR: Certainly.

BJ: Yes. Well he was in "The Benny Goodman Story" with the Louis Armstrong band. As a matter of fact he was one of the ones who taught me how to play and how to act and all that kind of stuff. So I always wanted to be a singer and a trumpet player. There used to be, at twelve o'clock every day all over the country, there was a band called The Claude Hopkins Orchestra. And they came from the Roseland Ballroom at twelve o'clock. Now this was during the days when they didn't have that many radio stations you know. Like ABC, CBS, NBC, and you could hear the Claude Hopkins band, and this guy would say,

"It's twelve noon on Broadway," and then you would hear Ovie Alston saying, "I will swim the ocean wide/I will take that great big ride." And man I used to go crazy. I'd say this has got to be one of the days.

MR: And they were probably playing live then too, right?

BJ: Huh?

MR: This wasn't a record you were hearing, this was the real band.

BJ: No, no, no, this was Claude Hopkins Orchestra, which was supposed to be like against Duke Ellington's band. As a matter of fact, the Roseland Ballroom, what I'd say, was one of the best jobs in the country, and it's still running. Now I hope I'm not giving them a big plug, but the Roseland Ballroom is still alive on 52nd Street. Then one day I think my mother came up to New York vacationing, and she breaks out that her son was the greatest trumpet player in the world.

MR: Better than Satchmo.

BJ: Better than Satchmo. So anyway Edmond Hall said really? So anyway they sent for me to come up here. The bus fare was fifteen dollars from Pensacola, Florida to New York. It came. And when it came, for some reason I didn't get the job. I'd been trying to say to myself, I'd played with him a couple of times, but I think there was another trumpet player named Louis Bacon that used to sing with Louis Armstrong. He was a ballad singer with Louis Armstrong. He got the job. But the next thing, I wound up with one of the greatest bands in the country, and I say this and God bless this man, he's still alive, he's 97 years old, but I was with the great Benny Carter band of 1941. And I guess you know, you've heard those records that were maybe twenty, twenty-five years ahead of the time. We recorded "I Surrender Dear" with him on trumpet. As a matter of fact Benny was one of the great trumpets, and is now, he's one of the great trumpet players of our time. He taught me a lot of things. I remember I had a fault of playing a little flat you know. And when I joined the band he told me to my face he says, "You're playing a little flat" he says, "I'll straighten that out." And he gave me a trumpet lick. Then that was it. And I haven't seen this man in many, many years. Incidentally, I know all these things like this because I'll tell you, in two weeks I will be 83 years old.

MR: I noticed that.

BJ: I will be 83 years old and one of the things, I'm just a little sad right now, because I knew Frank Sinatra, and not really, who knew Frankie? Not really, but I'll tell you something, I hadn't seen him but once in fifty years, can you imagine that? And I've been everywhere. Every place he went, we went, because you know the Erskine Hawkins band, we went everywhere.

MR: Can I ask you about when you moved to New York, did you come with your mother?

BJ: Huh?

MR: You came with your mother to New York?

BJ: Yeah. She left first.

MR: I understand you had some pretty famous neighbors across the way.

BJ: Oh yeah. You heard of my neighbors. Well the great Charlie Parker lived directly across the street from us in the Dewey Square Hotel. And every night he'd practice scales, and so once my mother said, "You know I'll really be glad when that guy learns how to play that thing." Talking about this, what's his name, Dick Wilson, the whole Andy Kirk band lived in a hotel called the Dewey Square Hotel that was directly across at 117th Street. As a matter of fact I took some of the musicians from here, and we paused in front of Bird's once and I told them, I said, I told them, this was Bird's nest. And he and I, we weren't that great of friends, but I was with Charlie Parker when he worked at The Hollywood Cafe on 116th Street. Now I could tell you, I could sit and tell you some stories about how many jazz musicians that came up between 110th and 125th Street. On 115th Street, where I came up in Harlem, I was about twenty-one, twenty-two years old. I would say that they had about eight or ten nightclubs with bands on 116th Street. And even Charlie, even they'd have cutting contests, you know what I mean? And during those days they were always trying to cut Charlie. I remember there was a saxophone player named Horse Collar they called him. And he'd be sitting there with his saxophone around his neck, and he'd say, "I'm waiting for him." And this went on. It cost a quarter to get in, and this was The Hollywood Cafe on 116th Street and Lenox Avenue. And nowadays I don't think there's hardly anything like that happening. But then Charlie and I joined a band, we joined the band together out in Queens, a show band. Now maybe we would have a little turn, but I don't know that much about Charlie Parker but I do know one funny story. We had an eight piece band named Cab Williams and his Orchestra, and he played for these chorus girls at a place called Ryan's out in Queens. So we had — we got our meal, one meal a night. So one night we were supposed to be there at six o'clock and one night old man Ryan would look out and see who was punching the clock. One night Charlie Parker broke a record. I don't think this story's ever been told. He broke a record of coming late. He rang the bell at twelve o'clock. And old man Ryan said, "Now who is that?" And that was Charlie Parker. Then from then on maybe it was because of whatever happened to him, you know what I mean? But he was a wonderful man, that's all I can say.

MR: You had to start work at six at Ryan's?

BJ: Um hum?

MR: You started at six o'clock. How late did you have to play then?

BJ: Well during those days, when you say how late did you have to play, there wasn't any unions, there wasn't any days off, there wasn't any vacation. When I first came to New

York there wasn't any vacations, there wasn't any unions or anything like that. As a matter of fact, I marched for the day off. I marched for unions, and at that particular time 802 was always — it wasn't segregated — but it was like uptown, downtown you know. The majority of the black musicians hung out at a place called The Rhythm Club downtown, and the white musicians were on the floor. But for just one reason I hung out downtown, and I would say since I'm interviewing you, I would say that if you look it up, in some of those look up books, and I have the pictures and everything, I was with one of the first integrated bands in the country. The first one was, I think we all — you'll have to look in your jazz books — the first one was by a fine band leader called Boyd Raeburn. Maybe you've heard of him, a saxophone player.

MR: Yes I have.

BJ: The next band was organized by one of Benny Goodman's saxophone players called Jerry Jerome. And he's still living God rest his — he's almost 90 years old, he's living in the south somewhere. But myself, John Simmons on bass, I can't think of the piano player's name, and Arthur Herbert on drums, we were the first band, integrated band to play at Kelly's Stables on 52nd Street. And one night, a great pianist named Nat Jaffe, said, "Hey man, this is one heck of a band, why don't we keep this thing together?" And we kept it together until everybody went their own ways. And I've looked up, I've tried to find out whatever happened to Nat Jaffe, but I think he must have passed away I think way back in the forties. And you see when you talk about the forties and fifties, sometimes you have to bring in subjects like racial segregation and things like that, which is, you try to stay away from that even in conversations, because we've solved some of our problems, you know what I mean? And this is still the greatest country in the world, but we've solved most of our social problems and maybe I'm happy to have gone through them. You know what I mean? We've been through a lot of different places and segregated, especially during the time of the Benny Carter band. We were on tour, and this was in 1941, and this was one of the great bands with the Parrish brothers, myself, Lincoln Mills. Most of them are dead. I think maybe the sad part of my life would be that most of all of my friends have passed away. The Erskine Hawkins band, they're all gone. There's only one, two, three — about three of us, four of us, Johnny Grimes, great trumpet player; Doris Rollin, one of the singers, then Erskine passed away about three years ago himself, and Jimmy Harris, the trumpet player, a fine trumpet player, and all of the Count Basie band, all of the Duke Ellington band and most of them have left this planet. They've left me here, maybe sometimes I could tell a lot of lies. I could tell a lot of lies if I wanted to. But I'd like to tell things that actually, really happened to them.

MR: Was there certain parts of the country that were worse than others as far as race?

BJ: Well, when you way worse than the others, most people would say that Mississippi was the worst place in the world to be, on any planet. But not really, it was four or five states that had awful what we called Jim Crow laws. But a lot of people could survive. I have been insulted when I was a young fellow, but I survived because my mother used to tell me all the time she says just get along with people and everything will come all right, because naturally she never wanted anything to happen to me. I've seen some awful things happen to people in the south. But it was just a part of our country of growing up, you know what I mean? It was a part of our culture, of being what we are today. And maybe, I couldn't say it was for the best, but I can say that everything's going to be all right. It's going to be better, you know? And one of the main things that I like to see was like I told, I was one of the first ones, like they used to say whatever happened to Bobby? And people would say oh man he's downtown playing with the white boys. Well that was true. But nowadays, even a saying like that is passé. People don't even say it like that. If you're good enough to play with anyone, you can play, and like in colleges and different things like that, social circles. And nowadays if a musician is talented, he can play with anyone. And I like to see, I have had several seminars with college kids you know, and I have never actually felt anyone was any other different color than mine, other than playing. And that's what I wanted to see. As you know, the University of Florida down in Gainesville, they had great bands down there, and the University of Florida A&M, that's where the Adderley brothers came from. We introduced them. The Erskine Hawkins band — can I tell the story?

MR: Please do, believe me. The Adderley brothers are my heroes. I love them.

BJ: Yeah. Well Nat and I, we did Orlando, Florida last year at Disneyland. He and I. Two cornet players, trumpet players. But during one night in Orlando, Florida, these two little kids came up to Erskine, and the place was packed. And these two little kids had their horns. So one of them said, "Could we play some?" Now this is during the bebop days. This is 1950, 1952. And we had Sonny Payne in the band. As a matter of fact, in the fifties the Erskine Hawkins band went out of business. And that was the best that we've ever played together. But things had gotten worse economically and everything. So we said okay, we'll let them play some. Man, these two kids, Cannon and the little cornet player, oh they played, this was something to hear. And the next thing you know, they were on big time. And there's a story out that they never had to audition, they never had to do anything. The story is that one night, on Boston Road in the Bronx, Nancy Wilson was singing and these two guys had a little gig for about twenty dollars, and someone from Capitol Records came in and heard them. They never looked back. You know what I mean? They both was very well educated. Florida A & M has a great reputation scholastically. Alabama State, this is one good thing about the southern colleges that had

bands. The Alabama State Teacher's College at Montgomery, the Tennessee State at Nashville, and then several other colleges, they've always had great bands and great musicians turn out, like Dwike Mitchell and all those guys from Jacksonville, Edward Waters College. But maybe that is because of the fact that there's not that much work, you know, when you come out of school. If I told you when I was like maybe, before I came up here, I was offered about maybe ten scholarships, not anything other than playing the trumpet. And at Alabama State, that was a state college, run by state money, tax money. We had to make our own breakfast, you understand? I didn't attend very long because there was always something better than that. But I'm writing a book, I'd like to write a book about the southern colleges, southern bands that didn't really make it. Because in New York, if you came to New York you were a New York musician. That's the reason why I came. But bands like Don Albert, Johnson's Happy Pals from Richmond Virginia, and most all of those musicians came to New York and got with big bands you know? And that's just about it. One of these days I'll write the book, maybe you'll finish it for me.

MR: Maybe I'd love to. Can you tell me how it came about that you joined Erskine Hawkins?

BJ: Oh, how I joined Erskine's? Well it's easy. Erskine's band stayed with us when we had our hotel, or whatever you called it—

MR: In Pensacola.

BJ: In Pensacola. Some people have a different word for it, you know what I mean? Because there was always a lot of females around, a lot of booze and everything. And they stayed with us. So when I came to New York they'd already, they were on top. They had played the Savoy Ballroom, and I was with, maybe you haven't heard of this band, one of the great bands of our time, I was with the Don Redman Band on Broadway at the Cafe Zanzibar. And we closed one night, closed on a Sunday. And they had heard of me. They knew me when I was a kid. So I came — I went out to get a paper, and when I came back my little wife and daughter, she said, "Erskine Hawkins' manager wanted to talk to you." I said, "About what?" She said, "He would like for you to join his band." I said, "Ah, naah, that's not me." So she says, "Well you're not working," and she brought it home to me she says, "You're not working, why don't you take your horn and get the bus and go on." At that particular time bus fare, 8th Avenue bus fare was a nickel. So I got on the bus at 113th Street, got off at 142nd Street, and heard this great band playing. And I went up and that particular night I think the draft board came up and took three. They took the late and great Mr. Renauld Jones, they took Jimmy Harris, took about five others. So that left the trumpet section empty. Then when I told Erskine, I laid it on the line, I said I don't play lead trumpet, I'm a trumpet soloist. So he said, "Ah we knew you when you was a kid, we know who you are." So I played. Then maybe you've heard of one of our

great trumpet players of our time, his name is Dud Bascomb, he was the one who made that trumpet solo in "Tuxedo Junction" with the Erskine Hawkins Band. So I stayed for a week, and the Savoy Ballroom, the money was very — the scale I think was only like $39 or something like that. So I stayed, and the guys began to like me. And as you know, Erskine's band never integrated. We never had — we never — and that was one of the things that really hurt me. We never had any people of color in that band, but I stayed with them twelve years. But I'm glad I did, because I will say that I got a chance to record. Erskine always had a trumpet soloist, and I will say that if you came by my house I could say that I recorded the most trumpet solos with another trumpet player, another great trumpet player's band, than anyone. And I don't regret it at all. That's one of the ways. I knew them from the south. They liked southern musicians. I don't think we've ever had a southerner in the band, the only one, the southern was maybe Kelly Martin, our drummer, that was with Erroll Garner later on in life. But I stayed with him a long time, and he paid me very well, Erskine did. I did all right with that band.

MR: Can you tell me about that recording session that you did "Tippin' In?"

BJ: The recording session?

MR: The recording session where you did "Tippin' In" with the mute?

BJ: Well how this came about, we had rehearsed "Tippin In" it was written by Bobby Smith. We had rehearsed it in Boston. And at that particular time the union was on strike. [Scats] which had like a wartime flavor. So we were supposed to come to New York but they told us instead of coming to New York, since we was already out west, to go to RCA Victor out by the stockyards in Chicago. So about five below zero I think that morning, we went and we'd all been drinking that night for some reason, I don't know why, we'd all been drinking that night. So we said well let's try that "Tippin' In." And we played it first and we went down, and during those days it was before tape. It was on the disks. The more we played it, the worse we got. So one of the A&R men I think was Russ Case, a fine trumpet player, he was RCA Victor's A&R man. He said let's go back and try the first one. So while I was going to the mic, I dropped my cup mute and he threw me, what we call — I can't think of them—

MR: A Harmon mute?

BJ: That's it. You know better than I do. A Harmon mute. And when it got to my solo the guys said, down low, and a million, I'd say two million records came from that, and twenty-one dollars for me.

MR: So you could buy your own Harmon mute, right?

BJ: Yeah. I could buy my own Harmon. Now the story is that is where the Miles Davis sound came from. It doesn't have to be true. I'd like for it maybe to be true because Miles, as you know Miles took my place with the Benny Carter band.

MR: I didn't know that.

BJ: A lot of people didn't know that. The morning that Benny left to go to Hollywood to do that movie — one of the big movies, I can't think of the lady's name — but anyway he got his break and he went and Miles was just a kid from East St. Louis. And he was downstairs waiting to see Benny then. Benny took him out west with him, and then I joined after that — I'm trying to think when I go back — then I joined Erskine Hawkins, that's when, after that. I wasn't too particular about joining Erskine Hawkins. I'll tell you the bands that I liked, and I never really got a chance to play with them too much. I liked Don Redman's band. I thought that Don Redman's band was like perfect almost, like you know, because you know with Taft Jordan, Dick Vance and all those great trumpet players.

MR: Plus he was a — Don Redman was a great arranger too, right?

BJ: Yeah. And Don Reel. And nowadays, you hear some of his stuff nowadays, "Chant of the Weeds" — have you ever heard that tune? Yeah "Chant of the Weeds," that was his theme song. Yeah. "Chant of the Weeds" and all that kind of stuff. Nowadays — Then, I was a singer, like I told you, and during those days — before I go any further I have to tell you this — I wrote all this stuff out two days ago, and I left it at home when I was coming out here today, for some reason or other. But during those days, Don had a song called "I Heard Yes I Heard" — "It wasn't told to me/I only heard." And when he found out I was a singer then that's when he wanted me to join his band. But like I told you before, if I had some advice to give a young trumpet player nowadays, I would learn to play the trumpet and sing. Because frankly, I'll tell you, I'll admit I'm a little crippled now, I don't know what's wrong with my knees. I don't run as fast as I did, you know. But if I was going to give a young musician any kind of advice, I'd tell him to take voice lessons. Because I'll tell you something, nowadays, even in this hotel, I worked in this hotel and made good money in this, where we are now, because I was a trumpet player-singer. And most trumpet player-singers, even Harry James sang. But who started was my good friend Satch, and Bunny Berigan. And I always say this about Bunny. Bunny is the one who put bad singers on the map. "I Can't Get Started" with you was his great saying, and Satch was a great, good singer, but Bunny sang out of tune, but everybody — [sings] I've been around the world — the minute any cafe owner saw me with my horn, the first thing he said, oh you're going to sing a few tunes too, huh? That means that the girl singer is out. You understand what I mean?

MR: Yeah, sure, you make yourself more valuable too.

BJ: That means that one Sally is out — during those days. Now, anything else would you like to know?

MR: Yes, I would love to know about getting a visit — you said King Oliver presented your—

BJ: Okay, well like I said, during those days, when the bands would come from New Orleans, like Papa Celestin, Don Albert, King Oliver, and other bands from Chicago, see bands that was based in Chicago, they all came from New Orleans, see? But that was their home town. And people would say, "Hey, let the kid play something — why don't you let the kid play something?" And even during those days you sang, and this was before microphones or anything, this was during the days when we used to sing Rudy Vallee with a megaphone you know. And we'd say, "Pass the mege."

MR: Pass the mege?

BJ: Yeah. Pass the mege. That was the megaphone. And then all of a sudden, one night, they put up this megaphone and then we played. And in my career, I could say starting with early one morning at Decca Records in 1953 when all this stuff, I saw it all happen. I saw the first wire recorder, I saw the first time on tape, the first time anything — well naturally, I'm 83 years old. And every time we went, now you've got to remember that we were with RCA Victor for many years. Erskine's band was with RCA Victor for ten. We saw the disks, well you know taking it off on disks, and what I really can't understand, some of the songs like the Tommy Dorsey Band, Artie Shaw, Duke Ellington and even Benny Carter, we did on disk and some of those qualities of these records are the same quality with all this stuff — you know what I mean — with all the electronics and all that. And we never had all that stuff. Like we had, I'll tell you what, "Tippin' In" had two mics. Out front for the trumpet and for the piano. That's it. And if you play that record nowadays, you will notice, look at all of that great stuff that Duke Ellington did over to RCA Victor. that wasn't any big microphones and each trumpet — I remember one morning we went in to Decca and Sonny Payne, they had such problems recording him until they even turned the drums backwards to get a tune, I can't think of the name of the tune. The next thing we went in, the engineer said, "Give us all you got. Everything you got." And this was after we went with King Records. And every time we went in there was always something new about electronics and stuff like that.

MR: Well the bands knew how to balance themselves, didn't they? You know, from playing live all that time.

BJ: Yeah, I guess so. I think that maybe some of the A&R men or people, some of the engineers, I think that maybe they knew more about sound than the electronic sound, because the electronic does it all for himself. You understand what I mean? Because some of the guys we've had, I can't think of the electronic men, the only one I can think of that gave us a couple of hits was a trumpet player named Russ Case. He had left one of the places to come and record with him. But nowadays, look at all this stuff. They've four or five, I don't even know the name of these things. Look at this. You understand? Microphones—

MR: I wanted to ask you another question about the early days. Did you ever play something, what they called "jitney dances?"

BJ: Who?

MR: Jitney dances? Where they'd have ropes up and people would come in and buy a ticket to dance? Is that what they called them? Perhaps they called them something different.

BJ: Jitney dances. Oh, well a jitney dance was like a lot of people came in at a low price, you know what I mean? We used to have, there were certain nights that they would have like fifteen, twenty cents, and you could hear Benny Carter, you could hear Fletcher Henderson, for twenty-five, they were called jitney dances. And in New York, up and down Broadway they had these jitney places, that the girls would come in and, oh now it comes back to me. They used to have tickets, and you would give the girl maybe a quarter to dance with her so many times. There wasn't anything wrong about it, that was just paying to have someone to dance with. You know what I mean? As a matter of fact they made a movie about it, about people coming in with their tickets, and I heard that there's one still left on Broadway even now somewhere. You go in, you give your ticket, and you dance. They call it jitney dances.

MR: When you were traveling on the road with Erskine Hawkins or any of the other bands, what was the hardest part of that, being on the road?

BJ: Well being on the road at that particular time, when I left Erskine the Civil Rights Act, this was before Martin and several other things happened. But the Civil Rights Act had just become a reality in our country. There wasn't some of the things, some of the violence hadn't started to happen. But people had begun to think for themselves you know what I mean. It even started down south. And there were hotels that we couldn't go in, there were restaurants that we couldn't eat in. And things, what were called during those days, that they were called Jim Crow in our society. But before Martin Luther King and President Johnson and other people saw things happening in our country, it changed overnight because if it hadn't our country was doomed. You understand what I mean? You see what's happening in other countries nowadays, they don't even have a Civil Rights, and some of the — what baffles me about some of the countries, most of the countries are of the same color. But we had all kinds of different people of different races and everything that had to come together as one person. You know what I mean?

MR: Right.

BJ: Yeah. Whether it was green, blue, yellow, white or whatever. But it had to be that way and this is not the end of it. You know? That's just the way. Now this I can tell you about what year this started in. Around 1952. Now in 1952, dances started, mixed dances started. And people started speaking up for themselves for their rights. You understand what I mean? That's just the way it was, it had to be that way you know? All right?

MR: Something had to change.

BJ: Yeah. Change.

MR: I understand that you got to play with Milt Hinton in a group called The Survivors?

BJ: Milt Hinton?

MR: Yes.

BJ: Well I was with Cab Calloway with Milt Hinton. As a matter of fact I have a tape, would you like it? Yeah, I have a tape that was taken at one of the music schools. I won't give them a plug. But Arnie Lawrence, you've heard of him.

MR: Yes, absolutely.

BJ: He got together a bunch of older guys, like Panama Francis on drums, myself, Milt Hinton on bass, the great Clark Terry — can you think of Clark Terry as an old man? Clark Terry on trumpet, Red Richards, God rest his soul he just passed away, Red Richards. Then Eddie Barefield, and we recorded. I'll give you one of the tapes, and Milt Hinton is — I was with Milt Hinton when he was young with Cab Calloway — when the whole world was young — with Cab Calloway. You have heard of Panama Francis?

MR: Certainly.

BJ: He's sick now. Then George Kelly, a great tenor player. I just saw him in "Moscow on the Hudson." Did you see the movie?

MR: Yes. Was that him playing?

BJ: Yeah.

MR: I'll be darned.

BJ: He and I came up together as kids, in the south, you know what I mean? And I just saw him. And we never did think that we'd get this old, but God kept us here, you know?

MR: Of all the leaders you've played with — Cab and Erskine Hawkins, and — was there one that was the strictest with you and the members of the band?

BJ: Benny. Benny Carter was a perfectionist. And he was someone to be looked up to because he was such a great musician. As a matter of fact he was such a great trumpet player until all the trumpet players that ever worked with him looked up to him. He wasn't that strict you know what I mean? I'm 83, Benny is about 90 I would say, around 90 years old. But I celebrated my 21st birthday with Benny in North Carolina with Benny. He treated me all right. You know what I mean? As a matter of fact I could say this for myself, and being from the south and being lucky, I always tried to do what was best for me to get along, even to get along with myself. We had, in some of the bands we had what we called some acteruppers, guys who drank too much and all of that. But some of them, Benny, he ran a tight ship musically you know. I had something that happened to me on a boat ride about three years ago. I was on a boat ride and this guy came up to me and he hummed this song [scats]. So I said oh my God, where have I heard this? And

I'm looking down on the Hudson River, and I said, "Pardon me" — he was a banjo player in a Dixieland band. And I said, "Where did you ever hear that song?" He said, "That was Benny Carter's opening number 48 years ago, named 'Pom Pom.'" He says to me, "I could hum everything that Benny Carter ever played, and I never — I wanted to see him and talk to him, but that was out of the way." And during those days now, you've got to remember, we didn't have any microphones. When I was with the Benny Carter band, we only used one mic. And I sang with that band too. I sang "I Can't Get Started" or whatever that was popular. And we had the great Maxine Sullivan. We had a singer called Roy Felton. And we made a couple of big hits, one was Vaughn Monroe's "There I Said It Again." We made that popular. I could tell you a story of things that some of the bands made popular, like [sings] "I've said it/I'll say it again" [scats]. Roy Felton made that, we made that popular with the Benny Carter band. Next thing I knew Vaughn Monroe—

MR: Picked it up and did a cover of it or something.

BJ: Picked it up — It was larceny, it was stealing.

MR: I understand you were singing on the radio when a very important announcement was made in 1945?

BJ: Well I swore I'd never talk about it because people, you know people may say that — right now — I think about it, the night, and I could tell you, the night that World War II ended.

It was ABC. And there was a lot of things happening. We were in the Hotel Lincoln. As you know, the Hotel Lincoln was the only one in New York that used black bands. Our band and Count Basie. As a matter of fact our band and Count Basie, maybe Lionel Hampton, were the only bands that played the big hotels. The Hotel Lincoln, when I was with Erskine we were the only bands that played the Hotel Aster. We were the only black band that played the 400 Club on Broadway, for some reason, I don't know. But we knew that there was something happening and we were in a rush to get back to the hotel because we got back and we took our seats and the song that I sang — I wasn't really the boy singer with Erskine, but I did my parts you know. And we were singing [sings] "Saturday night is the loneliest night in the week." And all of a sudden a guy came out and waved his hand and he said, "Ladies and Gentlemen, World War II has ended."

MR: Wow.

BJ: That hit us. And you know what day — that is what changed the world. And they just cut me out maybe, and they kept singing. But I tried to find out whether the Smithsonian, or maybe, I've looked for it in my own way to try to find out exactly — I know during those days we had what we called V-disks, large records like that that could take off two or three different, and people, you had to handle them with care because they would break

just like regular. And I know it was taken off on a V-disk but I don't think it was taken off like anything —

MR: Like the radio wire or something?

BJ: Yeah like the radio wire. I don't think it was taken off like that. But I think maybe during those days the Smithsonian Institute would have a lot of things. I've tried to look for it, and I've said, any many people oh come on, you'll never hear it. But someone had to be — this was at the Blue Room at the Hotel Lincoln, the night World War II was over, and man, you've never seen people — you've seen that famous photo of the sailor kissing the girl and all of that kind of stuff was happening. And then sadly to say, that was the beginning of the end of the big band era. That was the beginning of the end of the era because when television came in the early '50's, that was the end of it. But I still do all right, I can't kick. I have a gig tomorrow night.

MR: Well I understand we're going to do a little playing, filming a show at some point.

BJ: Still playing.

MR: So I want to thank you very much for your time, and we're going to go get set up in the next room.

BJ: Oh, great. And thank you. Thank you very much.

MR: On behalf of the college—

BJ: So we're going to play some later maybe. Thank you.

MR: All right.